

Grammar

Relative Clauses — who/which/that/whose (defining) and where/when/why

We use defining relative clauses to give essential information that identifies exactly which person, thing, place, time or reason we are talking about, without which the sentence would not make full sense. We use who/that for people, which/that for things, whose to show possession, where for places, when for times, and why for reasons. Defining relative clauses are not separated by commas.

Belirten (defining) sıfat cümleciklerini, hakkında konuşulan kişi, şey, yer, zaman ya da sebebi tam olarak belirlemek için gereken, cümlelerin anlamı için gerekli bilgiyi vermek amacıyla kullanırız; bu bilgi olmadan cümle eksik kalır. İnsanlar için who/that, nesneler için which/that, sahiplik için whose, yerler için where, zamanlar için when, sebepler için why kullanılır. Belirten sıfat cümlecikleri virgülle ayrılmaz.

When? Use a defining relative clause whenever the listener needs the extra information to know exactly who or what you mean; if you removed the clause, the sentence would become unclear or too general.

Dinleyicinin tam olarak kimi ya da neyi kastettiğini anlaması için ek bilgiye ihtiyacı olduğunda belirten sıfat cümlecikleri kullanılır; bu cümlecik çıkarılırsa cümle belirsiz ya da çok genel hale gelir.

Positive

- The person who/that helps me is my friend.
- The place where we meet is a café.
- The reason why she left is unclear.

Negative

- The person who doesn't help me isn't a real friend.
- The place where we don't usually go is quiet.

Question

- Is he the friend who called you yesterday?
- Is this the café where you met your friend?

Short answers

- Yes, he's the one who called.
- Yes, that's the place where we met.

Common mistakes

- ~~This is the girl which is my best friend.~~ → **This is the girl who is my best friend.**
- ~~That's the café, where we always meet.~~ → **That's the café where we always meet.**
- ~~He is the boy who's bag is red.~~ → **He is the boy whose bag is red.**
- ~~I remember the day which we met.~~ → **I remember the day when we met.**

1. The teacher _____ taught us last year has moved to another school.

2. Balıkesir is the city _____ I was born.

3. Choose the correct sentence.

- a. This is the friend which helped me.
- b. This is the friend who helped me.
- c. This is the friend where helped me.
- d. This is the friend whose helped me.

4. That's the boy, who's brother plays football with me. — *True / False*

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5. Put the words in order: the / I / trust / most / is / person / who / Elif

6. Combine: I have a friend. My friend's sister is a doctor. (*I have a friend...*)

7. The reason _____ we became friends was our shared love of music.

- a. where
- b. when
- c. why
- d. whose

8. That's the gathering _____ all my classmates met last summer.

9. Combine: I remember a day. We laughed together all day. (*I remember the day...*)

10. Which sentence correctly uses a defining relative clause without a comma?

- a. The café, where we meet is nice.
- b. The café where we meet is nice.
- c. The café, where we meet, is nice.
- d. The café who we meet is nice.

11. Do you know the reason _____ she moved to another city?

Defining vs. Non-defining Relative Clauses

A defining relative clause gives essential information without which the sentence loses its meaning, and it is not separated by commas. A non-defining relative clause adds extra, non-essential information about someone or something already identified (often a name or a unique place), and it is separated by commas. 'That' can replace who/which in defining clauses but not in non-defining clauses.

Belirten (defining) sıfat cümlecisi, çıkarıldığında cümlenin anlamını kaybettiği temel bilgiyi verir ve virgülle ayrılmaz. Belirtmeyen (non-defining) sıfat cümlecisi ise zaten tanımlanmış bir kişi ya da şey (genellikle bir isim ya da tek bir yer) hakkında ek, gereksiz olmayan ama zorunlu da olmayan bilgi verir ve virgülle ayrılır. 'That', belirten cümleciklerde who/which yerine kullanılabilir ama belirtmeyen cümleciklerde kullanılamaz.

When? Choose non-defining when the person or place is already clearly identified (a name, 'my mother', a capital city) and you are only adding extra detail; choose defining when the clause is needed to say exactly who or what you mean.

Kişi ya da yer zaten açıkça belirlenmişse (bir isim, 'annem', bir başkent gibi) ve sadece ek bir bilgi ekleniyorsa belirtmeyen cümlecik; tam olarak kimi ya da neyi kastettiğinizi belirtmek gerekiyorsa belirten cümlecik seçilir.

Positive

- The boy who called me is my cousin. (defining)
- Emre, who called me, is my cousin. (non-defining)

Negative

- The boy who didn't call me is my cousin.
- Emre, who didn't call me, is my cousin.

Question

- Is the boy who called you your cousin?
- Is Emre, who called you, your cousin?

Short answers

- Yes, he is.
- Yes, he is.

Common mistakes

- ~~My mother who lives in Balıkesir called me.~~ → **My mother, who lives in Balıkesir, called me.**
- ~~The friend, that helped me, is very kind.~~ → **The friend that helped me is very kind.**
- ~~My best friend Deniz who I trust most.~~ → **My best friend Deniz, whom I trust most, always helps me.**

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1. My father, who works at the hospital, is very supportive. — *True / False*
2. Choose the correctly punctuated sentence.
 - a. My sister who lives in İzmir, is a doctor.
 - b. My sister, who lives in İzmir, is a doctor.
 - c. My sister, who lives in İzmir is a doctor.
 - d. My sister who lives in İzmir is a doctor, is a doctor.
3. The book _____ I'm reading now is about a group of childhood friends. (defining, can use 'that')
4. Combine, making it non-defining: My teacher helped me a lot. My teacher's name is Ms. Kaya. (*Ms. Kaya, my teacher,...*)
5. Put in order: is / my / cousin / Deniz / who / lives / in / Bursa
6. 'That' can be used instead of 'who/which' in _____.
 - a. non-defining clauses only
 - b. defining clauses only
 - c. both types equally
 - d. neither type
7. Combine as a non-defining clause: Ankara is the capital of Turkey. Ankara has many good universities. (*Ankara, which...*)
8. The girl that is my cousin, lives in İstanbul. — *True / False*
9. My best friend, _____ I have known since childhood, always makes me laugh.